

RECRUITING STUDENTS INTO INTERCOLLEGIATE DEBATE: RESULTS OF A NATIONAL SURVEY

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Forensic administrators across the country face many of the same concerns. Most can relate to budget constraints, concern for travel safety, and coaching stress or burnout. The need to recruit students to the activity and their programs represents another continuing challenge for forensic administrators. Student recruitment in forensics can take a variety of forms. Forensic administrators can recruit students from the major or service courses, through public demonstrations/exhibitions, through campus advertising, and offers of scholarship support. This paper will address the challenge of recruiting students by looking at those who are currently involved with intercollegiate debate in an attempt to identify characteristics of those drawn to the activity. Furthermore, the study will attempt to shed light on areas where forensic educators might recruit students in the future.

The importance of student recruitment stems from the common need to justify the financial support and faculty resources devoted to programs. Forensic administrators and debate coaches have for decades promised (with good reason) that students who join debate programs would improve their critical thinking skills (e.g. Allen, Berkowitz & Loudon, 1995; Brembeck, 1947; Colbert, 1987; Colbert & Biggers, 1985; Howell, 1943; Murphy & Samosky, 1993). Bartanen (1994) explains in his text, *Teaching and Directing Forensics*, that a key to student recruitment is an understanding of why students would be attracted to the activity. His suggestion is to focus on promoting the valuable career and educational preparation, development of communication skills, fun, and the opportunity to meet people and share experiences (p. 52). He also explains the public relations techniques of word of mouth advertising, being publicly visible, and utilizing personal contacts are useful recruiting functions (p. 53).

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Kevin and Kendra Dean (1984) have previously reported a comprehensive approach for recruiting forensics students on campus. While their focus was with an Individual Events program, many of the same suggestions can be used for debate programs. Their suggestions begin in the summer when the admissions office is contacted to identify prospective students. A mailing list is then created along with a letter of introduction. Further advice is given with regard to hosting a team meeting early in the semester, establishing team and personal goals, and setting an early target date for the first tournament. During the season, they suggest the standard, but important steps of using campus public relations to highlight successes, keeping administration briefed on accomplishments, hosting a forensics showcase and late spring appreciation event for supporters, and keeping parents informed about the program.

Many debate coaches and forensics administrators are familiar with these practices and have put some of them in practice at their own institutions. Many also host high school events to help recruit new students. However, the recognized need to demonstrate financial viability to upper administration (e.g. Hunt & Inch, 1993; Rogers, 1991), the expressed need to recruit minority participants (e.g. Valdivia & Simon, 1997; Loge, 1990) the competition for students' extra-curricular time, and constraints unique to individual campuses (e.g. Preston, 1991) make student recruitment an increasingly formidable challenge.

The current study sought to help student recruitment efforts by surveying current participants about their backgrounds and views on debate. It was hoped that this effort could help identify some characteristics of students who have been drawn to intercollegiate debate. These results could then be used to offer concrete suggestions for recruiting new students into the activity. These results might also suggest areas that have been ignored or underdeveloped in recruiting efforts. Characteristics that are not present in today's debaters might exist because students with those characteristics have not been approached. Study results are also viewed in terms of which debate formats different students tend to participate in. The researchers sought to determine whether there were backgrounds or beliefs about debate among debaters who participate in different formats. The following research questions guided the present study.

RQ1: What characteristics identify today's intercollegiate debater?

RQ2: Which characteristics best predict participation in intercollegiate debate?

Method

Procedure. Surveys were mailed to 358 directors of debate programs in the United States. Mailing lists from the following debate organizations were used: National Debate Tournament (NDT), American Debate Association (ADA), Cross Examination Debate Association (CEDA), National Parliamentary Debate Association (NPDA), American Parliamentary Debate Association (APDA), International Public Debate Association (IPDA), National Forensic Association (NFA), and National Educational Debate Association (NEDA).

Directors were asked to distribute surveys to their debaters, recollect them, and return in the postage paid envelope. A cash incentive was used to encourage a higher response rate. Each school received only seven surveys to limit the chances of larger programs dominating the response pool. Response rate was based on the number of institutions responding. A total of 70 institutions responded for a response rate of 19.5 percent. While not ideal, this rate is similar to suggested acceptable rates for general mail surveys (e.g. Watt & Van Der Berg, 1995). A total of 286 completed surveys were received from the 70 schools.

Questionnaire. The questionnaire featured 14 items (please see Appendix for complete questionnaire). Items one through three assessed participants' demographic background (sex, ethnicity, and socio economic status). Item 4 asked respondents to report their participation in various activities in high school debate (i.e., cross examination debate, Lincoln Douglas debate, Individual Events, Student Congress, Radio/TV, Mock Trial, Theatre, Four H Speaking, and Model United Nations). Items five through 11 asked participants to report the number of speech and debate tournaments they attended during high school, whether they competed in forensics in junior high school, whether they attended a high school summer workshop, whether they believed that they had a knowledgeable high school debate coach, whether a sibling had competed in debate or forensics, if they participated in debate/forensics because it would benefit their professional career, and what debate activities they competed in during high school. Items 12 and 14 were open-ended items asking respondents to identify three benefits to participation in intercollegiate debate, three disadvantages to intercollegiate debate, and if participants felt that they had to give up personal and or educational opportunities in order to participate in debate/speech activities. Results from items 12 and 14 have been previously reported (Williams, McGee & Worth, 2001).

Data Analysis. Research question one was answered by computing frequency counts for each of the five categorical variables on the questionnaire (items five through 11). Research question two was answered by conducting a logistic regression analysis of the variables along each of the three intercollegiate speech and debate organizations: NDT, CEDA, and NPDA. Logistic regression, a version of the Chi-square test, is “an analysis of more than two variables measured on the nominal level...to identify explanatory models and patterns” (Reinard, 1994, p. 314). All associations are indicated by the values listed under the heading “Parameter Estimate” in Table Three. The closer a parameter estimate is to or exceeds the value of 1.0, the stronger the association between the variables (see Tabachnick & Fidell, 1996). Alpha was set at .05 for all significance tests.

Results

Characteristics of Intercollegiate Debate Competitors

Demographic Variables. Research question one asked what characteristics identify today’s intercollegiate debater? Descriptive statistics were computed to answer the first research question (see Table 1). Males and females appear to participate roughly equally in intercollegiate debate. While, the majority of competitors are White and from middle income households. Most of the respondents reported not having a sibling who participated in high school debate or forensics. Finally, the majority of respondents reported not participating in debate or forensics in junior high school (76.1%), not participating in summer workshops (67.0%), and having a knowledgeable high school speech coach (63.4%). Most participants reported attending in 10 or less speech and debate and tournaments in high school (66.9% cumulative), and not participating in debate and forensics for professional reasons (57.8%).

Table 1
Descriptive Statistics: Demographic Characteristics of Intercollegiate Debate and Forensic Competitors

Variable	Freq.	%	Variable	Freq.	%
Sex			Attended High School		
Male	163	57.2	Summer Workshop		
Female	122	42.8	No	191	67.0
Ethnicity			Yes	94	33.0
White	215	72.1	Reported Having a		
Black	16	5.7	Knowledgeable Coach		
Hispanic	19	6.8	No	104	36.6
Asian/Pacific Islander	10	3.6	Yes	180	63.4
American Indian	4	1.4	Professional Career		
Native Alaskan	0	0	Development		
Other	15	5.4	No	180	63.1
Socio Economic Status			Yes	105	36.8
Low	34	12.2	Attended Speech and		
Middle	219	78.5	Debate Tournaments in		
High	26	9.3	High School		
Sibling Participant			None	20	7.0
No	247	86.7	1-5	79	27.7
Yes	38	13.3	6-10	92	32.2
Competed in Junior High			11-20	55	19.2
School			21-50	30	10.5
No	216	76.1	50+	9	3.1
Yes	68	23.9			

High School Debate and Forensics Activities. Roughly half of the respondents participated in cross examination debate. However, participation in the remaining activities was less equitable (see Table 2).

Table 2
Descriptive Statistics: High School Activities of Intercollegiate Debate and Forensic Competitors

Activity	Freq.	%	Activity	Freq.	%
Cross Examination Debate			Mock Trial		
No	158	55.2	No	223	78
Yes	128	44.8	Yes	63	22
Lincoln Douglas Debate			Theatre		
No	214	74.8	No	173	60.5
Yes	72	25.2	Yes	113	39.5
Student Congress			Four H Speaking		
No	192	67.1	No	260	90.9
Yes	94	32.9	Yes	26	9.1
Radio/Television			Model United Nations		
No	260	90.9	No	247	86.4
Yes	26	9.1	Yes	39	13.6

Characteristics Predictive of Intercollegiate Debate Participation. Research question two asked which characteristics best predict participation in intercollegiate debate? Numbers of respondents in these organizations were 55, 123 and 122 respectively for NDT, CEDA, and NPDA. Many respondents reported that they participated in more than one form of debate (e.g. NDT and CEDA) and were coded into both categories. A logistic regression analyses was performed on intercollegiate debate participation in the three organizations and six measures of participation/background: (1) Number of Tournaments Attended in High School, (2) Participation in Summer Workshops, (3) Reports of Having a Knowledgeable Coach, (4) Professional and Career Development as a reason for participation, (5) Participation in Debate and Forensics in Junior High School, and (6) if a Sibling Participated in Speech/Debate Activities.

NDT participation was associated with lower numbered categories for the number of tournaments attended and participation in a summer workshop. This suggests that NDT competitors less frequently reported participating in high school tournaments and in summer camps. However, NDT competitors reported having knowledgeable coaches. The variables

Professional and Career Development, Participation in Debate and Forensics in Junior High School did not significantly predict participation in NDT, and Sibling Participated in Speech/Debate Activities. This suggests that for NDT competitors having knowledgeable coaches in high school influenced participation in intercollegiate debate more than Attending Tournaments in High School and Participation in Summer Workshops.

CEDA competitors reported less Participation in Summer Workshops, but reported Having Knowledgeable Coaches in high school. This indicates that CEDA competitors less frequently reported participating in summer camps and more frequently reported having a knowledgeable coach in high school. Finally, NPDA participation was associated with a strong significant association with the variable Participation in Summer Workshops, as well as a significant negative association with the variable Professional and Career Development. That is, NPDA competitors more frequently reported participating in Summer Workshops and less frequently reported that intercollegiate debate played a large role in their Professional/Career Development. Participation in Junior High School and having had a sibling Participate in Speech/Debate Activities did not significantly predict participation in NPDA. Refer to Table 3 for a complete list of regression analysis results.

Table 3
Logistic Regression Analysis (Maximum Likelihood Test):
Characteristics Predictive of Forensic and Debate Participation

Predictor Variables	NDT			CEDA			NPDA		
	$\wedge$	SE	χ^2	$\wedge$	SE	χ^2	$\wedge$	SE	χ^2
Number of Tournaments in High School	-.31	.14	5.14*	-.03	.11	.11	-.08	.11	.62
Participation in Summer Workshop	-.79	.38	4.12*	-.83	.35	5.64**	1.00	.36	7.97***
Had a Knowledgeable Coach	.90	.42	4.53*	.69	.35	3.86**	-.26	.35	.58
Professional and Career Development	.16	.09	3.01	.08	.08	1.07	-.16	.08	3.96*

Note. $\wedge$ = Parameter estimate. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Competing in debate/forensics in junior high school and having a sibling participate in speech/debate did not significantly predict participation in the three organizations on the collegiate level.

Discussion

Several implications emerge from this study with regard to the recruitment of intercollegiate debaters. Initially, a look at the demographic and regression analysis results provides some insight into how ethnicity, SES, and previous debate experience can effect

recruiting at the college level. Finally, results from the survey of high school activities provides some unique and possibly surprising findings regarding activities our current debaters were previously involved in.

Demographic Analysis. The economic background of participants was predictable in that the vast majority was self-identified as middle class. However, the fact that more were from lower than upper economic backgrounds might be surprising given the perceived financial costs associated with participation (e.g. travel, camps, evidence, and materials). For whatever reasons, the activity does not seem to attract large numbers of those students who would be best able to handle the financial stress of participation and the difficulty with competition limiting work opportunities (Williams, McGee, & Worth, 2001). Efforts to expand diversity and access to debate should not lead to the exclusion of recruiting students from stronger economic backgrounds. This conclusion must be tempered with the recognition that students were asked to categorize their background as high, middle, or low SES. It is possible that some students might be from what would typically be considered high SES, yet they listed themselves as middle SES.

While there is no evidence to suggest that large numbers of siblings follow their older brother or sister into debate, it is intriguing that nearly 24 percent of respondents reported some forensics activity in junior high school. However, participation or lack of participation in these events did not significantly predict participation in the intercollegiate level. One might speculate that efforts to increase debate activity in American junior high schools would result in greater participation at the high school, and then college, levels. In junior high, many students begin to identify their primary extra-curricular activities. For example, many who choose band in junior high continue in band, many who choose football, stay in football. If more students were able to choose debate in junior high, the numbers of participants at advanced levels would possibly increase. However, it may also be the case that the availability of more extracurricular activities in high school may interest those students who participated in speech and debate on the junior high school level and therefore interfere with a student's interest in continues participation.

College forensic administrators might also try offering Junior High only speech tournaments. Or try to incorporate Junior High students in their high school tournaments. College programs could also provide a valuable recruiting and service function by sponsoring workshops for area Junior High Schools. In many cases, this might involve taking the workshop "on the road" to area junior high schools.

High School Activities. The final three items in the demographic analysis provide more immediate assistance to debate coaches and forensic administrators wishing to recruit more students. Surprisingly, summer camp participation was not a significant predictor of students likely to compete in NDT or CEDA. Likewise, NDT participants were likely to have attended a fewer number of tournaments in high school. But, NPDA debaters did more frequently attend high school summer camps. Having a knowledgeable coach in high school did correlate with NDT and CEDA debaters, but not NPDA competitors.

The recruiting message that is taking shape suggests that much of the standard practice for recruiting students already enrolled or on campus should be supplemented with an active approach to get involved with the high school programs. More specifically, and somewhat surprisingly, the summer camps may not be the most fertile recruiting ground.

In light of this finding, possible recruiting suggestions would be to identify high school coaches in the institutions' normal student recruiting areas and include those coaches in the standard public relations and promotional literature that is sent to on-campus administrators. Intercollegiate forensics administrators, coaches, or debaters could also devote energy to working at summer workshops and camps where these students will be in attendance. Some might even choose to host camps, although considerable thought should be given to the recruiting tradeoff with the time and energy necessary to host a camp. Since over 60 percent of debaters reported having a knowledgeable high school debate coach, college forensics educators should work to identify the more prominent high school coaches in their area in an attempt to establish relationships with that coach and his/her program. Additionally, any outreach effort to create new "knowledgeable" high school debate coaches would, among other things, potentially benefit recruiting into the college program.

A final surprise in the study was the lack of student recognition of debate being related to their professional development. There was no correlation with NDT and CEDA debaters and a negative correlation with NPDA debaters who thought the activity was not part of their professional development. It appears that the recruiting pitch for prospective students might focus more on the social benefits of the activity. This is consistent with the analysis of the open-ended question that asked students to identify the benefits of intercollegiate debate (Williams, McGee & Worth 2001).

Respondents' previous activities provide a means for assessing where future debaters might be found. It might be assumed that current debaters were primarily involved in debate

in high school. While that was the most frequently identified high school communication activity, there is more to examine.

The percentage of respondents who participated in high school cross-examination debate was 44.8 percent. However, only slightly over 25 percent participated in Lincoln Douglas debate. More of the debaters in this study participated in theatre (39.5%) and student congress (25.2%) than in Lincoln Douglas debate. More surprising is the relatively narrow difference between the number of students who did cross-examination debate and theatre in high school. This might provide college coaches with a new direction to look for potential students. While the theatre student might typically be considered a logical candidate for individual events competition, this student has also frequently found her/himself in debate at the college level. Individual forensics directors might give some consideration to the performance element of some high school activities (e.g. LD debate, student congress, theatre) that were participated in by today's collegiate debaters. College coaches in different parts of the country can seek performance-oriented activities present in their region and attempt to recruit those students.

Possibly the overall message for recruitment to be found in this analysis is that less than half of the debaters in this survey participated in cross-examination debate in high school. Forensic administrators and coaches frequently seek out the experienced student who will understand the debate philosophy and terminology and be easier to coach and ready to travel sooner than the novice counterpart. This study suggests that more than half of intercollegiate debaters entered the activity with no cross-examination debate experience, and only 25 percent had LD experience. These students came from somewhere else. Forensic administrators and coaches need to be mindful of this insight and seek new students from new places.

This study sought to survey intercollegiate debaters from across the nation to determine how to better recruit the students of the future. The study would have benefited from more respondents from the APDA, NFA LD, NEDA, and IPDA organizations. The results might be more typical of students who have been attracted to NDT, CEDA, and NPDA formats. We encourage future research into the vital issue of student recruiting and especially from institutions which participate in the organizations that were under-represented in this study.

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Appendix

Debate Participant Survey

Directions to participants: Thank you for participating in this national survey of intercollegiate debate participants. Please complete the survey below and return it to your coach/director. It should only take about ten minutes to complete. It is hoped that these results will help forensics educators learn more about who is attracted to intercollegiate debate, why, what limitations the activity presents, and how new participants might be included in intercollegiate debate. Please circle the choice that best represents you and your debate activity.

1. Sex: M / F

2. Race: White Black Hispanic
 Asian/Pacific Islander
 American Indian Alaskan Native Other (please specify)

3. Socioeconomic background:
 Lower economic background
 Middle economic background
 Upper economic background

4. Which debate activities do you participate in?
 NDT CEDA NPDA ADA PDA
 NEDA APDA NFA L-D
 Other (please specify)

5. How many speech and debate tournaments did you attend in high school?
 0 – 21 21 – 50

6. Did you compete in any type of debate/forensics activity in junior high school?
 Yes No

7. Did you attend one or more summer debate/forensics workshops in high school?
Yes No
8. My high school provided at least one coach who was knowledgeable about competitive debate/forensics.
Yes No
9. I had a sibling who competed in high school debate/forensics.
Yes No
10. You participate in debate/forensics because it will benefit your professional career choices.
Yes No
11. Which debate activity/activities did you compete in during high school?
Cross examination debate Mock trial Lincoln Douglas debate
Model United Nations Individual events Theater/musicals
Student congress 4-h public speaking High school radio or TV
Other(s) (please specify) _____
12. What would you identify as the three greatest disadvantages that accompany your intercollegiate debate participation?
1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
13. What would you identify as the three greatest benefits that arise from your intercollegiate debate participation?
1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

14. Have you ever given up other personal or educational opportunities because of your debate participation? If yes please describe briefly.

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